had arrived in India with the human bombs. Likewise, Santhan also eventually spoke. He disclosed to Verma that Shanmugham could throw light on Sivarasan's movements. Upon inquiry, Manoharan of the Tamil Nadu Police (attached to the SIT) figured that Shanmugham had gone underground. Verma realized that he would have to crack Mahalingam to get to Shanmugham.

He offered Mahalingam a barter deal. The SIT would set him free in exchange for Shanmugham. Mahalingam knew it was a trap. He did not give in and kept denying he knew his whereabouts. A rich overlord who was rolling in money, courtesy of the LTTE after years of penury, Shanmugham had the reputation of having the local police and politicians on his payroll. Verma gave Mahalingam a break and had a small chat with Ragothaman on the side.

A little later, Mahalingam was put through the same drill of interrogation and this time it yielded some results. He revealed that he had ferried Sivarasan and the entire gang, including Dhanu, Shubha, Murugan, Nixon, Neru, Suthenthiraraja, Athirai and a young man with one leg, on 1 May and landed at Kodiakkarai. While Sivarasan still remained elusive, the role of the INT group under Sivarasan's leadership was getting substantiated by all its members.

Suddenly Ragothaman walked into the interrogation room and disclosed that Shanmugham had been shot dead in an encounter by the Tamil Nadu Police. However, the local police were unable to identify the body. He asked if Mahalingam could. Verma took Mahalingam along for identification. They landed up in a dilapidated building. But there was no sign of an encounter having taken place there. And neither did Verma and Ragothaman seem bothered about Shanmugham's body not being there. There were no police personnel there either. Mahalingam sensed he had walked into a trap and that his time was over. Verma pointed his gun at him. It worked. Mahalingam broke down and agreed to cooperate with the SIT in tracking Shanmugham.